

Thomas Tompion and English watchmaking

No. 133

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026

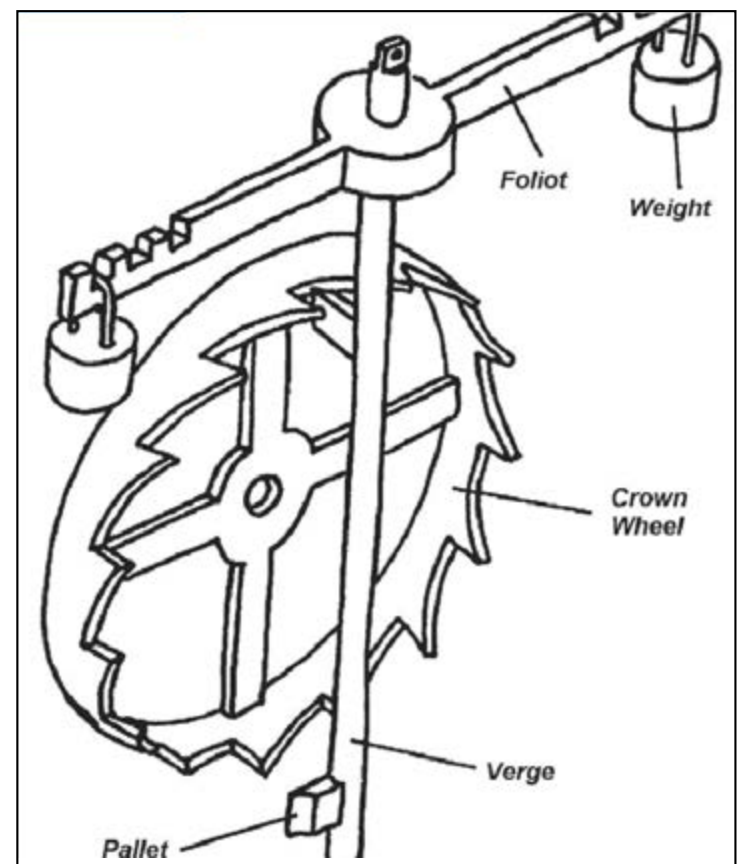
Thomas Tompion was born in 1639 in Bedfordshire. He came from a family of blacksmiths, who made iron church clocks.

He trained as a clockmaker in London and became known as the "Father of English watchmaking" because he helped make clocks and watches much more accurate.

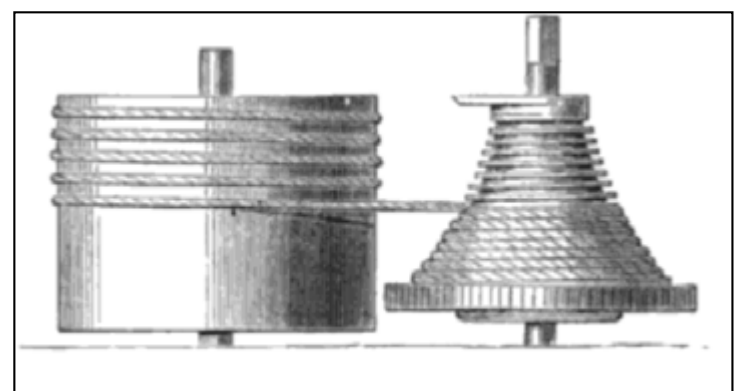
Working with Robert Hooke, Tompion made one of the first spring-driven watches. It was presented to King Charles II in 1675.

Tompion was famous for using high-quality materials and skilled craftsmen. He also trained George Graham, who became an important clockmaker.

Thomas Tompion died in 1713. His work helped make English clocks and watches some of the best in the world. He and George Graham are buried in Westminster Abbey.



Schematic of verge and foliot mechanism



Mainspring barrel and fusee